

Mav and the Ten-Billion-Dollar Meat-Nap

The set of the Arby's commercial was a fever dream of protein. Maverick stood in the center of the studio, flanked by the Professor Bucktooth doll. In front of them sat the "Meat Mountain" sandwich, and next to it stood the new mascot: **Sir Flopsy-Steak**, a rabbit made entirely of flank steak and deli ham, held together by toothpicks and sheer willpower.

"Maverick! This lagomorph is a structural catastrophe!" the Bucktooth doll hissed. "He is sweating brisket! His ears are made of pastrami! If he hops, the seismic vibrations will cause a total sandwich-collapse!"

"Just hold the mustard, Professor," Mav whispered. "We have a job to do."

Mav delivered his lines with Sam Elliott-inspired grit, even as Sir Flopsy-Steak shed a single tear of au jus. The producers were so impressed they handed Mav a check for **\$10,000** on the spot.

"Aha! Capital!" Bucktooth squeaked. "We must invest this in a foundational future! We must buy every scratch-off ticket in Clovis!"

Mav agreed. They spent the entire afternoon visiting every gas station in a five-mile radius. At the last stop, the cashier wept as Mav handed over the final thousand. "Son," the man sobbed, "you could have bought a college education. Or at least a very large, sensible inflatable castle. Why the tickets?"

"The Beaver said it's about the odds, man," Mav replied, scratching a ticket with a lucky nickel.

Suddenly, Mav's eyes bugged out. "Professor... look."

Mav hadn't just won. He had won the **"Super-Omega-Gigantic-Galactic Jackpot."** The screen on the ticket-checker read: **\$10,000,000,000.**

"TEN BILLION?!" the doll shrieked. "WE CAN BUY THE ENTIRE LUMBER INDUSTRY! WE CAN GOLD-PLATE THE DAMS!"

Mav immediately spent \$5 billion on a time machine called the **Chrono-Cheddar 3000**. He spent the afternoon jumping back in time to give his past self better Christmas presents (mostly high-end mustard and Furbies with pre-unlocked belly games). Feeling exhausted from the space-time travel, Mav decided to take a thirty-minute nap.

While he slept, the space-time continuum buckled like a cheap plywood bridge. When Mav opened his eyes, he was lying on a park bench in a world that felt... different.

Standing over him was a living, breathing, four-foot-tall beaver in a tuxedo.

"Hey, kid. You got any spare change?" the beaver asked. His voice was raspy and unfamiliar.

"Who are you?" Mav asked, blinking. "Are you related to the Professor?"

"I don't know any Professor, kid. I'm just a guy tryin' to make it in this crazy world," the beaver said.

Mav looked toward the street. On the sidewalk, **Taffy Stamburger** and **Cheap Whiskey** were wearing tattered rags. They were frantically doing the **Macarena** next to a cardboard sign that read: *'WILL DANCE FOR BINARY CODE AND SANDWICH CRUSTS.'*

"Aha! A target!" the living beaver muttered. He reached into Mav's pocket with lightning speed, swiped Mav's wallet—which still contained the remaining \$5 billion—and tossed the entire thing into Taffy's collection bucket.

"Here ya go, boys! Don't spend it all on frosted tips!" the beaver laughed, disappearing into a nearby bush.

"MY WALLET!" Mav yelled, but his vision began to blur. Everything started spinning like Sir Flopsy-Steak in a centrifuge.

Mav woke up with a jolt in his own bedroom. He looked around.

The Professor Bucktooth doll was sitting on his nightstand, a silent, polyester puppet once again. Mav checked his pockets. The lottery tickets were gone. The billions were gone. The time machine was nowhere to be found.

"It was a dream," Mav sighed, rubbing his head. "The meat rabbit... the ten billion... the living beaver... it was all just a crazy nap."

Mav walked over to his window and pulled back the curtain to look at the street.

He froze.

Riding down the center of the road were **Taffy Stamburger** and **Cheap Whiskey**. They were both wearing **floor-length leopard-print pimp coats** and riding **custom bicycles with solid gold spokes**. Their hair had been meticulously styled into **bright neon frosted tips** that shimmered in the Clovis sun.

"I'm telling ye, Whiskey!" Taffy's voice echoed through the glass. "The frosted tips provide a 40% increase in narrative swagger! We look like billionaires from the future!"

"Darn tootin'," Cheap Whiskey replied, popping a wheelie on his gold bike.

Mav looked at the Bucktooth doll. The doll's button eyes seemed to twinkle for a second.

"Toodahoo, Maverick," a faint, squeaky voice whispered from the felt mouth. "The space-time continuum is a very expensive place to visit."

Mav just sat back down on his bed, looked at his empty wallet, and decided that the next time he won ten billion dollars, he was definitely keeping it away from beavers—alive or puppet.

